



**All-round prowess:** The author, during his time as head coach, encouraged Ashwin to value his batting, even promoting him up the order during the 2016 West Indies tour, citing his technique and ability to bat ahead of Wriddhiman Saha.

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was hard, and I could use the shine. You would get a bit of drift or swing overseas with the new ball. Unlike overseas, you rarely have any breeze in India because the stadiums are closed. I also loved the new ball because you could extract more bounce. That's what Ashwin did, and he was highly successful.

On a personal level, I appreciated his approach to the game. He always had his views. It's not easy to convince an Ashwin. I might say he could try something for his benefit, but he would always counter, 'This is what I think I can do, and I'll still get you wickets.' He would have his views and stick to them. High-quality bowlers do that, working on the batter and getting him out. Ashwin was good at setting up batters.

I also encouraged him to value his batting. When I was the coach on the tour of the West Indies (in 2016), we moved Ashwin up the order because I, for one, believed he had the technique and ability to play ahead of (Wriddhiman) Saha. Ashwin batted at No. 6 and scored a couple of hundreds in Antigua (113) and St. Lucia (118). He was 'Man of the Match' in both those games.

I also felt he could be an ideal all-rounder. India always talks about fast-bowling all-rounders. You had quality spinners and batters in Ashwin and Jadeja. They were two good batters when in form and could bat anywhere in the middle order. They should have played in every match outside India.

I have encountered comparisons between Ashwin and Harbhajan (Singh). I don't believe in comparisons. I am the last person to say one is better than the other. Harbhajan could get serious bounce, bowl a different line outside the off-stump, and make the batter play through the offside. He mostly bowled over the stumps to the right-handers. Harbhajan also had

the doosra. Both were great bowlers.

Ashwin was more stump-to-stump and rarely bowled the outside off-stump line to the right-hander from over the stumps. He was more round-the-stumps and tried to get the batter out LBW. The game has changed. The players' mindsets have changed. The batters have changed, too, in terms of approach.

I remember telling Ashwin he should get to 600 when he crossed the 500 mark — and then 619. The way he was going, he had a very good chance. He didn't have a great series against New Zealand, but that was one in 14 years.

Players who have contributed for such a long period deserve a grand farewell. They need to be sat down and offered an appropriate plan on how you want them to leave the game. I was very disappointed with the way Ashwin left. Many cricketers in the past missed out on a farewell, too. The kind of benchmarks he has set won't be easy for anyone to live up to. He served Indian cricket with distinction.

**As told to Vijay Lokapally**